allowed any Indian citizen to be treated this way & that the Govt had no contingency plans in place for this exodus.'[7]

Whereas some leaders, despite being from the opposition parties, understood the magnitude of charging up more people to come out on the streets and appealed to them not to do so in the interest of the nation. For instance, on 29 March, the chief minister of New Delhi, Arvind Kejriwal, tweeted in Hindi:

> Some people are urging to go back to their village. The Prime Minister has appealed to us to stay where we are. I also appeal to you that you not return to your villages and stay put where you are. Such large gatherings can make you vulnerable to catching the virus. And through you, the virus can further spread to your villages and your families. It will spread to various parts of the country and if that happens, it will be very difficult for the country to emerge out of the grip of the virus. I assure you that [the] Delhi government has made arrangements for all your food and shelter requirements. It is in the interest of the country at this point that you don't return to your villages.[8]

Chief ministers began to coordinate with each other to ensure that as a united force they provide all possible assistance to the migrants. The chief ministers of states from which most migrants hail which includes states from the Indian heartland comprising Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and others like Telangana and Andhra Pradesh began outreach measures to the chief ministers of destination states such as Maharashtra, New Delhi and Karnataka to ensure that folks hailing from their states were provided welfare and taken care of.

On 28 March, responding to concerned calls from these chief ministers, Uddhav Thackeray, chief minister of Maharashtra, responded in a televised address, 'If human beings from other states have to survive, then humanity must be shown to them. It is in our culture and is our responsibility to look after them.'[9]

However, this spirit of camaraderie eroded quickly in the upcoming weeks as reports of migrants not being adequately provided for by state governments surfaced. Catalyzing that was the realization by the opposition parties that this could become a major point to politically dent the popularity of the ruling establishment. Therefore, hand in hand with their